Minutes of the
General Government Committee Operating Budget Meeting
Held in the River Plate Room, Ajax Town Hall
At 7:00 p.m. on March 4, 2019

Alternative formats available upon request by contacting:
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Present:	Chair - Mayor	S. Collier
	Regional Councillors	M. Crawford
		S. Lee
		J. Dies
	Councillors	R. Tyler Morin
		A. Khan
		L. Bower

1. Call to Order

Budget Chair Collier called the meeting to order at 7:00 p.m.

2. Disclosure of Pecuniary Interest

Councillor Bower declared a pecuniary interest with respect to Section 2 of the Operating Budget, 'Recreation, Culture & Community Development – Facilities' (pages 45-47), and 'Recreation Programs & Active Living' (pages 48-49), as a family member is employed by the Town of Ajax in the Recreation, Culture and Community Development Department aquatics section.

Mayor Collier declared a pecuniary interest with respect to Section 2 of the Operating Budget, 'Recreation, Culture & Community Development – Facilities' (pages 45-47), and 'Recreation Programs & Active Living' (pages 48-49), as a family member is employed by the Town of Ajax in the Recreation, Culture and Community Development Department aquatics section.

3. Opening Comments

Sheila Strain, Director of Finance/Treasurer, provided a brief presentation reviewing the contents of the Operating Budget report and the recommendations contained therein. S. Strain discussed services provided through the Operating Budget, budget framework, 2019 base and exception increases, significant base budget items, significant exceptions, managing budget increases, assessment growth, mitigation of budget increases, debt reduction reserve, 2019 property tax, 2019 estimated combined tax rate increase, annual Ajax property tax by service, and impact on the average residential property.

Mayor Collier, Budget Chair, thanked Town staff and the treasurer for their work on the budget, and discussed increased service levels to be delivered through the 2019 Operating Budget.

4. Opening Public Comments/Questions

Mayor Collier invited opening comments and questions from members of the public. There were no public comments or questions.

5. Review of Budget

Mayor Collier led members through a section-by-section review of the 2019 Operating Budget.

Section 1 - Budget Report

There were no questions or comments on the budget report.

Section 2 - Operating Budget

Members provided questions and comments on the following sections within the Operating Budget:

- **Mayor & Council (p. 17-18):** Members discussed increasing direct communication with residents through Council mailers and newsletters, and inquired about funds allocated in consideration of the legislated elimination of the 1/3rd tax exemption for Council members. Shane Baker, Chief Administrative Officer, noted that no decision has been made yet regarding how to address the legislative change.

- **Office of the CAO (p. 19-20):** Members inquired about funds allocated for new health and safety equipment. S. Baker responded to questions from Committee members.

- **Legislative & Information Services (p. 25-27):** Members inquired about costs and considerations associated with moving towards a proactive by-law enforcement model, and revenues from mobile sign permits. Derek Hannan, Acting Director of Legislative & Information Services, discussed service levels and mobile signage permitting.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Administration (p. 31-32):** Members inquired about distributable labour costs identified in the budget. S. Strain noted that distributed labour costs are budget neutral and shared among the Operations & Environmental Services division budgets.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Operations (p. 33-34):** Members inquired about increasing grass cutting and litter pickup services, and increased costs related to crossing guards. Catherine Bridgeman, Acting Director of Operations & Environmental Services, and S. Strain responded to questions from Committee members.

Amendment

Moved by: L. Bower

That staff be directed to examine options and costs associated with increasing service levels for grass cutting and litter pickup, and to report their findings to the Council meeting of March 25th for Council to consider whether to include the necessary funding in the 2019 Operating Budget.

CARRIED

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Environment Services (p. 35-36):** Members asked questions regarding costs to replace garbage bins in public parks and salting activities through the Seniors Snow Removal program. C. Bridgeman discussed the replacement process for park garbage bins. Dave Meredith, Acting Director of Planning & Development Services, described salting activities through the Seniors Snow Removal program.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Building Maintenance (p. 39-40):** Members inquired about costs for fuel and fluctuations in fuel prices. C. Bridgeman explained the process used to estimate fuel costs.

- **Recreation, Culture & Community Development – Recreation Programs and Active Living (p. 48-49):** Committee members inquired about revenues generated from general operations and differing revenue amounts between program offerings. Tracey Vaughan, Director of Recreation, Culture & Community Development, discussed levels of demand for programming and the upcoming Recreation and Culture master plan.

Section 3 - Staff Requests

Members provided questions and comments regarding Staff Requests within Section 3 of the Operating Budget:

- **Cultural Programmer - St. Francis Centre - Conversion from Part Time (p. 60):** Members inquired about the objectives of the proposed staff request. T. Vaughan reviewed programming activities at the St. Francis Centre and the objectives of converting the position to full-time.

Section 4 – New/Expanded Programs and Initiatives

There were no questions or comments from Committee members regarding New/Expanded Programs and Initiatives within Section 4 of the Operating Budget.

Section 5 - Ajax Public Library

Committee members asked questions regarding increased collections costs. Donna Bright, Chief Librarian, discussed the impact of foreign exchange rates on the Library's collections costs and licensing for e-books and audio books.

6. Closing Public Comments/Questions

There being no further comments or questions from Committee members, Mayor Collier invited closing comments and questions from members of the public.

Ceciley White, 10 Heatherwood Road, inquired about financial support for sports groups seeking relief from the Town's user fees. T. Vaughan discussed the Town's user fee practices and noted that fees would be examined as part of the Recreation and Culture Master Plan process. Mayor Collier noted that discussions with various user groups are ongoing.

Chris Baker, 69 Darley Street, inquired about future operating costs associated with the Audley Recreation Centre Phase 2 and Service Improvements described in Section 4 of the Operating Budget. Mayor Collier and S. Strain described cost annualizations in 2020 as a result of the Audley Recreation Centre Phase 2 and Service Improvements. Mr. Baker noted that the overall tax increase stated in the budget report should be more prominent in future budget years.

7. Budget Recommendation

Members separated the 'Recreation, Culture & Community Development – Facilities' (pages 45-47), and 'Recreation Programs & Active Living' (pages 48-49) sections for the purposes of voting. Mayor Collier and Councillor Bower abstained from voting on the separated sections due to their declared pecuniary interests.

Moved by: S. Lee

That Council approve the 2019 Budgets for Recreation, Culture & Community Development Facilities (pages 45-47) and Recreation Programs & Active Living (pages 48-49).

CARRIED

Main Motion as Amended

Moved by: S. Lee

That Council approve the 2019 Budgets, inclusive of transfers from Debt Reduction and Strategic Initiatives Reserves, as follows, subject to the following amendments:

1. That staff be directed to examine options and costs associated with increasing service levels for grass cutting and litter pickup, and to report their findings to the Council meeting of March 25th for Council to consider whether to include the necessary funding in the 2019 Operating Budget.

Budget	2019 Budget Amount	2019 Increase
Town of Ajax	$55,158,000	$1,856,700
Library Operating Grant	4,896,500	187,300

Audley Recreation Centre Phase 2			
	Town	471,500	471,500
	Library	427,900	427,900
Total Audley Recreation Centre Phase 2		$899,400	$899,400
Service Improvements		644,800	644,800
	Total	61,598,700	3,588,200

CARRIED

8. **Adjournment** (7:58 p.m.)

Moved by: A. Khan

That the March 4, 2019 meeting of the General Government Committee Operating Budget be adjourned.

CARRIED

Chair

D-Clerk